

Rating: 7/10
Developer: Crystal Dynamics
Publisher: Eidos
Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive
Contact: sales@e-xpressindia.com
Price: Rs 699

di9itGAMING PC

XFX GeForce 8800Ultra;
Intel Core 2 Duo E6600; 4
GB RAM; Windows Vista
Ultimate x64; WD 250 GB

have to jump, but the camera hampers you from finding out where exactly you have to jump to.

The game's also riddled with checkpoints so you never really have to save your game, but this also has the potential to be an annoyance—if you backtrack, walk into a checkpoint and die, you end up undoing all the work you did before backtracking.

I liked the direction that *Legend* took the franchise in—more action made it a lot more entertaining—but TRA turns its focus strongly on puzzle-solving. The rare dose of action that you do get from the few enemies isn't much—they're freakishly dumb: bears who can't climb stairs, for example, and are quite content standing around while you perch on high ground and finish them off at your leisure. One nice touch is the Adrenaline Dodge, which lets you dodge charging enemies with a bullet-time effect, though you end up hardly using it due to reasons quoted in the previous sentences.

The environments are large—massive at times—and puzzles are spread out across them. This can get pretty confusing: you'll find yourself solving (or choosing not to solve) mini-puzzles only to realise much later that they were part of a much bigger picture. This can get pretty frustrating if you don't realise the big picture quickly enough, but is quite exhilarating when you have your Moment of Realisation.

TRA's huge environments lend themselves to a fairly boring feeling of solitude—you encounter other life forms very

rarely, and unlike in *Legend*, you don't have the banter between Croft and her assistants to keep you entertained. It's just you and the puzzles. It gets so boring that you'll soon want to befriend the odd wolf, if only the blasted creatures would stop trying to kill you.

The Croft Manor is back too, so when you're done with the game, you can spend some time in Lara's family home solving more puzzles and unlocking rewards—including cheats and new outfits for Lara.

TRA looks fetching, and it's a humungous joy that it'll run just fine even on my now-ancient NVIDIA 6600, but it doesn't seem to exploit newer, more powerful cards like we'd have expected it to—our monstrous 8800 Ultra seems wasted on it. Still, keeping in mind that there are many people who don't jump at the latest graphics card the second it comes out, you can enjoy the game without shelling out for new hardware.

Final Thoughts

TRA isn't as much fun as *Legend*—it sadly forsakes the action and intensity that we saw with the latter: one of the caveats of remaking an old game, I guess. The puzzles, however, are very well-designed, and while challenging, aren't especially tough—at no point did I find myself completely lost. It's also longer than *Legend*, so the fun doesn't have to end prematurely. Give it some well-deserved space on your Lara Croft shelf—if nothing else, it's miles ahead of the original.

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com



All right...who hit the big red button on the time machine?



I may not have textures, but I'm still cooler than you